I-Corps Sites Workbook: Week 3

Planning out your customer interviews ahead of the interview itself is imperative for collecting valuable, **unbiased information** about your customers' **wants, needs, and desired outcomes**. Ideally in your interviews, you want to ask questions that test the **most important, uncertain, and/or riskiest beliefs** that you have for your business. Customers' answers to your questions will provide critical information that will help you decide what the next steps should be for you and your business.

Step 1) Prioritize your riskiest assumptions (~5 minutes)

List your team's current business hypothesis below:

My customer, **Agricultural Networks**, has a problem and it is that **they can not optimize without centralizing**.

The value my customers will receive when my solution solves their problem is **internal and external optimization in distribution and informed decision making.**

What are the riskiest assumptions within your business hypothesis? Phrased another way, **what assumptions** about current customer behaviors, **if were not true, would cause your business to fail?**

Risky Assumption #1: I believe… **Network participants can not optimize distribution.**

Risky Assumption #2: I believe... **Network participants can not optimize operations**

Who do you need to interview to determine if your assumptions are valid or invalid?

Customer Segment to Interview: Farmers Market, Agricultural Extension Programs, Unions

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Step 2) Identify your intended learnings from the interviews (~3 minutes)

Based on your riskiest assumptions, what is it that you'd like to learn from your interviews? Below are some examples. **Pick one or two goals tops!**

Examples of interview goals:

- ☐ To understand the potential customer's top 2-3 problems
- ☐ To understand the potential customer's current processes
- ☐ To understand further downstream implications of the problem
- ☐ To understand try to quantify the severity of the problem
- ☐ To understand the limitations of the customer's current solutions
- ☐ To understand the decision-making process
- ☐ To understand what the current budget is for solving the problem

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Step 3) Design your interview questions (~7 minutes)

Based on your goals, **formulate/select 3-5 open-ended questions to ask** that will help you validate, invalidate, or clarify your hypotheses. **Questions should be tailored to better understand a customer's behaviors, habits, and processes.** Consider the following in order to develop a flow of questions in your interviews:

- Break the ice
    - For questions to help with this interview goal, reference the *Sample Market Validation Questions Worksheet* section "**Intro/Icebreaker Questions"**
- Understand the potential customer's top 2-3 problems and current processes
    - For questions to help with this interview goal, reference the *Sample Market Validation Questions Worksheet* section "**What problems do potential customers recognize?"**
- To understand further implications of the problem and try to quantify the severity of the problem
    - For questions to help with this interview goal, reference the *Sample Market Validation Questions Worksheet* section "**What are the effects of not solving these problems?"**
- To understand the customer's current solutions and their limitations
    - For questions to help with this interview goal, reference the *Sample Market Validation Questions Worksheet* sections "**How are potential customers currently solving these problems?" and "What would prevent adoption of your solution?"**
- To understand the decision-making process & what the current budget is for solving the problem
    - How much do you currently spend on this problem?
    - What budget do you have allocated to this? Who controls it?
    - How much would you pay to make this problem go away?
    - For more questions to help with this interview goal, reference the *Sample Market Validation Questions Worksheet* section "**How do potential customers make purchase decisions?"**
- Closing Questions
    - For questions to help with this interview goal, reference the *Sample Market Validation Questions Worksheet* below under "**Closing Questions"**

Unbiased *Sample Market Validation Questions Worksheet* is available at the end of this worksheet.

List your 3-5 open-ended questions here:
1. In what ways does decimating information seel most difficult
2. What initiative is your organization engaged in to better connect with the community
3. What lasting impact does your organization wish to have
4. How have you used technology to accomplish this externally or internally
5. In what ways are you most unhappy with how you technologies role or lack thereof?

Remember, these 3 to 5 questions will set up the outline of your interview, but you will almost certainly need to follow up with "why" questions to extract the insights you need to test your hypotheses.

Step 4) FINAL CHECK: Practice interview (~10 minutes)

If you have time, run a practice interview with your mentor (or the other teams in your breakout room) pretending to be your customer. Are you testing a risky, non-obvious assumption? Does your question set align with proving your hypothesis valid or invalid?

BONUS: If you still have additional time, discuss with your mentor (or the other teams in your breakout room) how you will reach out and secure interviewees in your customer segment.

Sample Market Validation Questions

Intro/Icebreaker Questions

- [Specific qualifying questions related to what you want to learn]
- When did you first hear about [x]?
- How did you first become interested/get involved in [x]?
- How much time do you spend on [x] in a given day/week/month?
- Who handles [x]?
- Tell me about your role at [company].
- What are your top responsibilities related to [x]?
- How long have you been working with [company]?
- With what department and business unit are you affiliated?
- How many people report to you?
- To whom do you report?

What problems do potential customers recognize?

- Could you walk me through [process] from start to finish? (And ask followup questions as they speak…Who is involved? How long does it take? etc)
- Of [problems x, y and z], which would you say is your top challenge?
- Can you walk me through a typical day in your work?
- How do you currently do [x]?
- Do you find it hard to do [x]? Why?
- How important is [x] to you?
- What keeps you from doing [x]?
- What's the hardest part of your day?
- What's the hardest part about being a [job title]?
- What are the top 3 challenges for someone in your position?
- What are some unmet needs you have?
- What solution do you wish you had that doesn't exist yet?
- What tasks take up the most time in your day?
- What could be done to improve your experience with [x]?
- What keeps you up at night related to [x]? Why?
- What is the first thing you would change about your work?

What are the effects of not solving these problems?

- Why is [x] a problem?
- What happens when [x] is not done?
- Roughly how much time does solving for [problem] currently take?
- Roughly how much money has been spent on solving [problem] over [time period]?
- How many people are affected by [problem]?
- How do you feel about the current situation?
- What would be the impact of solving for [problem]?
- How would doing your job/day/task be different if you had a solution for [problem]?
- What percentage of day/week do you spend fixing [problem]?
- How much would you be willing to pay an external contractor to solve [problem]?
- If you had a solution to [problem], what would it mean to you?

How are potential customers currently solving these problems?

- How do you currently solve for [problem]?
- What do you like about your current system/process?

- What could be improved with the current system/process?
- What other options for solving this problem have you explored?
- What other possible solutions are you familiar with?
- What has held you back from changing to something else?
- Tell me about [problem].
- What are you currently doing to solve [problem]?
- How do you typically work around this problem?
- Do you expect this problem to improve, worsen or stay the same in the upcoming year?
- Are there, in your perspective, ways technology can help with this problem?
- Tell me about the last time you did [x]?
- How do you do [x]…why did you choose this method?

What would prevent adoption of your solution?

- What other options for solving this problem have you explored?
- What do you like about your current system/process?
- What could be improved with the current system/process?
- What has held you back from changing to something else?

What sources do potential customers use to get relevant information?

- What sources do you use to get information about [x]?
- From which sources do you typically learn about new products or technology?
- Where do you get new information on [x]?
- What are some of the blogs, websites or publications that you read?
- Who are your influencers, or who do you take advice from?
- Who are some industry visionaries that you respect?

How do potential customers make purchase decisions?

- Tell me about your company's decision making process for [x].
- Who is involved in decision making?
- Tell me about the last time you were involved in purchasing [x].
- If you identify the need for a new product in your department, how does your team typically go about purchasing the solution?
- All things considered, what is the typical length of the approval process?
- What does the corporate purchasing process look like?
- How do you typically purchase new tools?

Closing Questions

- [Summarize some of your key takeaways] – is that correct?
- It sounds like [x] is very important to you, while [y] is not. How accurate is that?
- What else should I know that I didn't ask?
- Do you know anyone else I can speak with who might also have this problem?
- Are you open to a follow-up conversation?
- Can I keep you in the loop on our progress?